CONNECTED INTELLIGENCE

PROMPT PLAYBOOK

Battle-tested prompts for your real work.

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MODULE 4
Exercise Worksheet

Module 4 — Reference: Zones & Power Phrases

Your G/Y/R zone tells you which prompting approach to use. The Power Phrases are precision tools you embed deliberately — not every prompt needs all 7.

Zone-to-Approach Mapping

Zone	Approach	When to Use	Complexity
Green	**Zero-Shot**	Clear task, AI has enough context, output is easy to verify	Low — just ask
Yellow	**Few-Shot / CoT**	Pattern-dependent output; you want AI to reason step by step	Medium — examples + reasoning
Red	**Full Scaffold**	High-stakes output; structure + verification built into the prompt	High — engineer the guardrails in

The 7 Power Phrases

Phrase	What It Does	Best Zone
"Act as [role]"	Activates a specific expertise frame	Yellow
"Deep research"	Signals thoroughness over speed; broader scope, more sources	Yellow
"First principles"	Bypasses convention; reasons from foundations, not templates	Yellow
"Devil's advocate"	Gets the counterargument; essential before decisions	Yellow / Red
"Constraints first"	Establish limits before generating; prevents unrealistic output	All zones
"Format as [X]"	Specifies output structure upfront; prevents reformatting	All zones
"Verify and cite"	Requests sourcing and self-check; reduces hallucination	Yellow / Red

Module 4 — Example Prompts

Three complete example prompts — one per zone. Notice how complexity scales with stakes, and how Power Phrases are embedded deliberately.

Green Example — Content Creation (Zero-Shot)

> **Power Phrases: "Format as," "Constraints first"**
>
> **Constraints first:** 200–250 words, LinkedIn audience (marketing professionals), no buzzwords, conversational tone, no fluffy opener.
>
> Write a LinkedIn post about why most AI prompts fail — not because of the model, but because of missing context. **Format as** a short punchy post: 1-sentence hook, 3–4 short paragraphs, 1 closing question.

Why it works: Task is clear, stakes are low, format is specified upfront. The constraints carry the brief.

Yellow Example — Client Proposal (Few-Shot)

> **Power Phrases: "Act as," "Constraints first," "Format as"**
>
> **Act as** a senior management consultant writing a proposal for a mid-market client. **Constraints first:** audience is a CFO with limited time, max 1 page, no technical jargon, dollar amounts must be confirmed before inclusion (leave as [TBD]).
>
> Here's an example structure that worked: [Executive Summary / Problem / Proposed Approach / Investment / Next Step].
>
> Write a first draft proposal for a 90-day operations audit. The core problem: $40K/month in process inefficiencies. Our solution: a 3-phase diagnostic. **Format as** the structure above, one short paragraph per section.

Why it works: Example structure (few-shot) removes format ambiguity. "Act as" sets expertise. CFO framing shapes tone.

Red Example — Strategy Decision (Full Scaffold)

> **Power Phrases: "First principles," "Devil's advocate," "Verify and cite"**
>
> I need to decide whether to expand into a new market segment this quarter. Walk me through this in 3 structured steps:
>
> **Step 1 — First principles analysis:** What does a rational decision to expand actually require to be true? List the 5 core conditions.
>
> **Step 2 — Devil's advocate:** Assume I've already decided to expand. What are the 3 strongest arguments against this decision?
>
> **Step 3 — Verify and cite:** Based on Steps 1 and 2, what are the 2 most important things I need to verify with real data before making this call?
>
> Context: [paste relevant org/market context here]

Why it works: Scaffold forces structured reasoning, not opinion. The 3-step sequence ensures AI can't skip the hard part.

Debugging Checklist

When a prompt returns weak output, run through these before rewriting from scratch:

- ☐ Did I include my Master Prompt context, or am I prompting cold?
- ☐ Is the task specific enough? (Vague task = vague output)
- ☐ Did I specify format, length, and audience?
- ☐ Is the output failing on content or structure? (Different fixes)
- ☐ Did I give an example of what "good" looks like?
- ☐ Is this a Green task I'm overcomplicating — or a Yellow I'm under-briefing?

Module 4 — Your Prompt Playbook (1 of 3)

Start with tasks you do at least once a week. Zone assignment first — that determines your approach before you write a single word.

Prompt Entry 1

Task:

Zone: G / Y / R

Approach: Zero-Shot / Few-Shot / CoT / Scaffold

Prompt:

Power Phrases used:

Quality (1–5):

Notes:

Prompt Entry 2

Task:

Zone: G / Y / R

Approach: Zero-Shot / Few-Shot / CoT / Scaffold

Prompt:

Power Phrases used:

Quality (1–5):

Notes:

Prompt Entry 3

Task:

Zone: G / Y / R

Approach: Zero-Shot / Few-Shot / CoT / Scaffold

Prompt:

Power Phrases used:

Quality (1–5):

Notes:

Prompt Entry 4

Task:

Zone: G / Y / R

Approach: Zero-Shot / Few-Shot / CoT / Scaffold

Prompt:

Power Phrases used:

Quality (1–5):

Notes:

Prompt Entry 5

Task:

Zone: G / Y / R

Approach: Zero-Shot / Few-Shot / CoT / Scaffold

Prompt:

Power Phrases used:

Quality (1–5):

Notes:

Playbook Reflection

Which zone has the most prompts? Is that intentional, or does it reveal an avoidance pattern?

What task do you keep doing manually that should be in this playbook?

Which prompt surprised you — worked better than expected, or worse?